hoped Édouard was one of these hostages and would soon be released.

Another German officer appeared. He stood in front of the woman with the basket. “Madame, I shall convey this to your husband.”

Léa could see the disappointment on her face. “May I speak with him?”

“Discussions with saboteurs are not permitted. The men are kept in isolation.” He clicked his heels and left.

The woman clutched her hands in front of her and padded across the hall to the door.

Léa gripped her own basket. How could she persuade them to let her speak with Édouard? The salon door opened, and a soldier emerged, striding over to her.

“Mademoiselle, papers please.”

Léa reached for her identity card in the front pocket of her dress. His gaze shifted between her and the photo. “Why are you in Combleux? You should be in Orléans.”

“My father and Monsieur LeBlanc were friends from school. Every autumn, we would come and help the family with the *vendange*.” She cleared her throat. “Madame LeBlanc’s daughter isn’t well today, so she asked me to bring his food and clothing.”

The soldier’s eyes were as empty and black as a starless sky. Outwardly Léa met his gaze, but inside, every nerve in her body pricked. He yanked the basket from her, nearly spilling its contents on the parquet.

“I’ll bring it to Monsieur LeBlanc,” he said.

“Pardon, monsieur, but there is an important question I must ask Édouard LeBlanc.”

“Not until after his release.” He stepped away and it took all of Léa’s control not to reach out and touch his arm to pull him back.

“It concerns Weinführer Brucker’s orders . . .” He paused. “The Weinführer requisitioned the LeBlanc vinery’s harvest for industrial alcohol. Monsieur LeBlanc had been in the final stages of production at the time he was arrested.” She squeezed her hands at her sides, summoning strength. “I’m now in charge and there’s an unusual smell coming from two of the vats. Fermentation seems to have stopped. If he can tell me what to do, I might have a chance to save the ethanol for Weinführer Brucker.”

She was venturing onto dangerous ground. What if the officer checked the *chai* to verify her story? She’d be caught, and then who would deliver